

County commissioners reverse decision to pay for automated license plate readers

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In an unusual about-face, Lucas County commissioners voted Tuesday to rescind previously approved funding for license plate surveillance in Lucas County.

At a commissioners' meeting the week prior, the commissioners unanimously approved a \$250,000, four-year contract between the sheriff's office and Flock Group, a security technology company.

Flock Group provides its signature Falcon LPR camera systems, which, in conjunction with its proprietary software platform, allow operators to monitor and track license plates and vehicle details throughout its operational zone.

According to the previously approved resolution, Lucas County would pay the company \$62,500 per year for its software platform and for 25 Falcon cameras.

At Tuesday's meeting, Commissioner Pete Gerken announced the resolution to rescind, previously unscheduled on the day's agenda.

"I did vote yes on that [previous resolution]. Having time to reflect on my vote, I would like to rescind the approval of that agreement," Mr. Gerken said.

He told the other commissioners that, despite previously voting to approve funding without argument, he later realized Lucas County should not further the "mass surveillance" of its citizens.

"It is inappropriate for the sheriff, in the time of budget constraints on all of us, to spend \$250,000 to mass surveil our community without any intended outcome," Mr. Gerken said.

He added that systems like the Flock license plate readers couldn't be trusted with the vast amounts of data they collect, and that such programs have had "chilling effects on our population, especially the minority population."

The original agreement with Flock, presented by Kristie Mundt of the Lucas County Sheriff's Office on July 15, would have committed Lucas County to a four-year contract running through May, 2029.

That day, all three commissioners passed the agreement without any questions or concerns, and it was Mr. Gerken who first moved to pass the motion to fund the initiative.

He and Anita Lopez voted Tuesday in favor of the resolution to rescind.

Commissioner Lopez was also concerned about Flock's effectiveness and said she felt it was "reasonable" to rescind the agreement.

Ms. Lopez said she hopes to see the data on how Flock has "been used in other areas, how it has helped [in] preventing crime or identifying individuals who may be wanted in other jurisdictions." She also said she prefers a one-year contract, rather than the previously approved four-year contract.

She said she appreciated the fact that the commissioners were able to review their previous decision, rather than sticking with a bad decision.

"Too many times, elected officials make a vote, have questions afterward, and then are too afraid to come back forward and say 'let's review this again,'" Ms. Lopez said.

Commissioner Lisa Sobecki welcomed the idea that concerns with Flock should be addressed again, but said she preferred to withhold on canceling the contract until after the commissioners made an educated decision on how to proceed.

Earlier in the meeting, Mr. Gerken had another impromptu moment, when he publicly pushed back against a Toledo Blade op-ed by Lucas County Treasurer Lindsay Webb.

Ms. Webb's piece, [published July 19](#), lambasted the commissioners for overextending its borrowing so much that it endangers core services.

Mr. Gerken denied that core services were under threat.

"She's wrong. She's uninformed on this," Mr. Gerken said. "Our bond ratings are good, we've increased wealth, we have maintained good reserves."

Mr. Gerken also added that the county treasurer should not be commenting publicly about these issues.

"She's the treasurer. Her job is to do two things: collect taxes and collect delinquent debt," he said. "I would suggest maybe she ought to stick to that."

When presented with Mr. Gerken's comments Tuesday afternoon, Ms. Webb said Mr. Gerken previously approached her for help regarding bond issuances for the conversion of the Park Inn into a Hilton Garden Inn and Homewood Suites, but didn't "like the answer" she gave.

"The commissioner came to me and asked me to help him with the short-term issuances for the hotel. I proposed a strategy to pay down that debt. They did not like the answer, and now, according to their own policy, this year they have to come up with a strategy for paying down that debt," she told The Blade.

Ms. Webb was referring to policy 36 of the Lucas County Commission, which outlines its debt management policy. Ms. Webb also said she felt that the commissioners should re-examine its debt management policy, which was last updated in 2009.

"The very policy that should govern their decisions about debt issuances dates to 2009, which makes it outdated," she said.

She also responded Tuesday to Mr. Gerken's statement that it was improper for her to write a Letter to the Editor.

While the commissioners makes the ultimate spending decisions, she said, “I am responsible for paying for those decisions, so I am doing my job by raising questions on behalf of the taxpayers that I serve.”

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